

Abhyupacāra: A Yogācāra Grammar of Metaphor

Abstract

This dissertation, based on my summary and critical review of *A Yogācāra Buddhist Theory of Metaphor* by Roy Tzohar, hereafter referred to as Tzohar (2018), investigates Sthiramati's pan-metaphorical claim of language as reconstructed by Tzohar (2018). The monograph explores the inter-sectarian discussion on the topic of metaphor (*upacāra*) between non-Buddhist schools of Indian philosophy and Buddhist schools. Most importantly, it introduces the formula revolving around *upacāra*, i.e., the primary referent is absent from its locus of reference, and its variations for different schools of thought. What requires our caution is to distinguish the traditional metaphor from a rhetorical perspective and the metaphor on the conceptual level within Yogācāra's framework of reasoning. Tzohar (2018) somehow blurs the boundary. Meanwhile, to offer an alternative to Tzohar's (2018) proposal of the underlying mental causal process as the common ground for the communication between a simpleton and a bodhisattva, the dissertation puts forward the concept of "the inter-accessible point of inference". Furthermore, Tzohar (2018) falls short of demonstrating why such terms as "the other-dependent pattern", which is the tenor for a series of vehicles of "a magic trick, a mirage, a dream trace, a shadow, a reflection, a valley echo, the moon in water", is metaphorical on the conceptual level within the framework of Yogācāra's pan-metaphorism, although Yogācāra philosophy has already entailed the absence of the primary referent in a top-down manner. To address this issue, the dissertation attempts a corpus-assisted study to approach in a bottom-up manner Yogācāra's pan-metaphorism from the perspective of traces of reification as an indication for metaphor on the conceptual level. Based on the assumption of "root metaphor ($\sqrt{\text{metaphor}}$)" proposed in §§ 2.6.2.1, the dissertation has found three schemata for the metaphors of suffering, *saṃsāra*, *nirvāṇa* and *dharma* in terms of the non-existent "self" and "phenomena", i.e. "the self contained in a phenomenon", "the self towards a phenomenon", and "the self evaluates a phenomenon".

Keywords: *upacāra*, Yogācāra, corpus-assisted

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Abbreviations

<i>AKBh</i>	<i>Abhidharmakośabhāṣya</i> [Vasubandhu]
<i>AS</i>	<i>Abhidharmasamuccaya</i> [Asaṅga]
<i>BBh</i>	<i>Bodhisattvabhūmi</i> [Asaṅga]
<i>LAS</i>	<i>Laṅkāvatārasūtra</i>
<i>MS</i>	<i>Mahāyānasamgraha</i> (<i>theg pa chen po bsdus ba</i>) [Asaṅga]
<i>TApaṭ</i>	<i>Tattvārthapaṭalaṃ</i> of the <i>Bodhisattvabhūmi</i> [Asaṅga]
<i>Triṃś</i>	<i>Triṃśikā</i> [Vasubandhu]
<i>TriṃśBh</i>	<i>Triṃśikābhāṣya</i> [Sthiramati]
<i>VS</i>	<i>Viniścayasamgrahaṇī</i> (<i>mam par gtan la dbab pa bsduBa</i>) [Asaṅga]
<i>YB</i>	<i>Yogācārabhūmi</i> [Asaṅga]

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1 Introduction

This dissertation, based on my summary and critical review of Tzohar (2018), examines Sthiramati's pan-metaphorism of language as reconstructed by Tzohar's work. At the beginning, it is necessary to explain the title of this dissertation, *Abhyupacāra*: A Yogācāra Grammar of Metaphor.

The Sanskrit word *upacāra* has such meanings as “metaphor” and “figurative language use”. The coined term *Abhyupacāra* follows the morphological pattern of Abhidharma. If interpreted metaphorically from a linguistic perspective, Abhidharma can be understood as a grammar of *dharma*, a meta-language characterising *dharma*. Similarly, *abhyupacāra* can be conceived of as a meta-language characterising *upacāra* within the Yogācāra framework.

It should also be noted that the term “Yogācāra” as used in the title refers specifically to early Yogācāra.

In this introductory chapter, I will articulate my motivation and objectives for writing this dissertation, clarify its significance, and present an overview of its structure.

1.1 Motivation

As a former linguistics student, I have long been interested in the relationship between language and cognition. Last year, as I began my studies in Buddhist studies, I read Tzohar (2018), one of the few works that examines the phenomenon of metaphor and its relationship with consciousness in the context of Buddhism, as stated by this book that “few studies of figurative language in Buddhist philosophy exist” (Tzohar 2018, 3). Tzohar's work, which will be discussed in detail in the chapter of literature review, attempts to reconstruct Sthiramati's view of language, a pan-metaphorical theory of meaning, by drawing on intertextual references to discussions of metaphor among non-Buddhist Indian and Buddhist schools of thought.

The primary insight of Sthiramati's pan-metaphorical theory of meaning, as analysed by Tzohar (2018), is that metaphor is not merely a literary ornament but also reflects a fundamental conceptual mechanism that is distinct from those posited by non-Buddhist Indian philosophical schools and Madhyamaka philosophy.

Tzohar (2018) is a philosophically dense reading, with complex concepts condensed into approximately 300 pages, making it overwhelming to one who is new to Buddhist studies or unfamiliar with Indian philosophy. Thanks to Professor Mathes's courses on Mahāyāna Buddhism and Yogācāra models of reality, I am able to unpack the messages conveyed in the book to some extent. Thus, I feel motivated to summarise Tzohar (2018) in order to present it in a concise manner and point out the crucial weaknesses of his reconstruction.

Although I am now more motivated to write on other topics as my knowledge of Buddhism grows, the die is cast. I will try my best to write in accordance with the principle of right speech.

1.2 Objectives

As stated previously, my dissertation aims to summarise Tzohar (2018) both as a literature review and as an introduction to the inter-sectarian debate on the theme of metaphor in ancient India. This move serves a dual purpose. First, it enables me to clarify my own understanding of early Yogācāra in general and of a linguistic approach to early Yogācāra in particular. With the attic of my brain stacked up with an abundance of philosophising and reasoning over the past academic year, I hope at least to rescue a casket from it and sort out its contents. Second, since not every reader is familiar with Indian or Yogācāra philosophy, a section of this dissertation devoted to providing essential background information becomes indispensable. Even if the remainder of this dissertation turns out to be nonsensical to the reader, this summary is expected to serve as a readily understandable introduction to the under-researched area of metaphor in Buddhism. Moreover, it should be noted that the reconstruction by Tzohar (2018) should be taken with a grain of salt, whose crucial weaknesses will be discussed later in the dissertation.

My second objective is to provide a way of understanding Sthiramati's pan-metaphorism with the help of corpus linguistics, adopting an approach different from that used by Tzohar (2018) in his case study.

1.3 Structure

Chapter Two is the Literature Review. As mentioned above, the chapter is primarily concerned with critically summarising the main arguments for the reconstruction of Sthiramati's theory of metaphor presented in Tzohar (2018). Recognising that the original work may be challenging

for readers unfamiliar with Indian and Buddhist philosophies, this chapter attempts to reorganise its contents in a more structured way and to supplement them with necessary background knowledge not provided in the book. Additionally, it is important to approach Tzohar's (2018) reconstruction with some skepticism. Its key weaknesses will be pointed out. For example, Tzohar (2018) holds that the basis for successful communication between sentient beings and bodhisattvas is the common underlying causal mental process, which is to me a wrong argument. Instead, I propose "the inter-accessible point of inference" as the basis of intelligibility between beings of different levels of attainment. Furthermore, at the conclusion of Tzohar (2018), a case study is presented where the reconstructed theoretical framework of Sthiramati is applied to the analysis of the role and meaning of lists of figures and similes that are commonly found across the Mahāyāna literature. This case study, however, seems to operate from a traditional rhetorical perspective rather than the conceptual level that Sthiramati seemed to envision. Therefore, I intend to explore how Sthiramati's theory can be understood otherwise. The case study will be discussed later in the dissertation.

Chapter Three focuses on the methodology employed in the dissertation, which is primarily corpus-assisted text analysis. It will introduce the fundamental methods of corpus linguistics and explore how these techniques can contribute to the study of Buddhist texts. The text to be analysed is the Lotus Sūtra. Available in Sanskrit, Classical Tibetan and Chinese versions, the sutra is renowned for its extensive use of metaphors and parables. Although the version to be analysed in this dissertation is the English translation by 84000, as analysing versions of other languages would require excessive translation and glossing, the methods used here can be applied to other versions in future studies. A preliminary quantitative investigation into the Lotus Sūtra will be conducted.

Chapter Four is devoted to the analysis of the Lotus Sūtra in order to demonstrate a way to understand Sthiramati's pan-metaphorism, offering an interpretation different from the case analysis presented by Tzohar (2018), on the basis of "root metaphor ($\sqrt{\text{metaphor}}$)" proposed in the dissertation.

Chapter Five concludes this dissertation.

2 Literature review

To reach the pantheon of Yogācāra in a dense forest, one must traverse a winding path, along which enigmatic figures emerge, each advocating the doctrines of their own traditions, striving to sway our resolve to reach our destination.

Within the interconnected web of Indian intellectual traditions, Sthiramati's theory did not arise independently. Rather, it can be considered the result of refuting non-Buddhist and Madhyamaka ideas, on one hand, and refining Yogācāra reasoning, on the other.

The summary of Tzohar (2018) will serve as the foundation of the literature review. The reconstruction of Sthiramati's pan-metaphorical view of language by Tzohar (2018) will be summarised in a step-by-step manner to facilitate the reader's understanding of the inter-sectarian conversation concerning the relationship between a word and its referent in India. The outlined knowledge of the debate on the issues of metaphor throughout Indian intellectual history is indispensable for understanding the establishment of Sthiramati's theorisation of metaphor.

The original text will be reorganised and enriched with the philosophical foundations of respective schools of thought, since their patterns of reasoning regarding metaphor are shaped by their underlying philosophies. I hope that I can turn the philosophically dense work into a relaxing reading. This chapter would appear to be a lengthy literature review, yet it is already a streamlined and adapted version of Tzohar (2018). It has to be presented as such, starting from non-Buddhist schools of Indian philosophy due to the tradition of inter-sectarian discussion about *upacāra*. Sthiramati has to be introduced gradually; otherwise, few would understand what I have been working on.

The literature review will be structured sequentially into the following major categories: non-Buddhist schools of Indian philosophy, the Grammarian traditions, Buddhist perspectives, and Sthiramati's theorisation. In the discussion of non-Buddhist Indian philosophy, attention will be given to the schools of Mīmāṃsā and Nyāya. The Grammarian tradition will be explored with a focus on Bhartṛhari. For Buddhist perspectives on metaphor, the ideas of Madhyamaka and Yogācāra thinkers prior to Sthiramati will be examined. Ultimately, all these come down to the thought of Sthiramati.

Now let's begin our journey.

2.1 Mīmāṃsā school

Upon entering the forest, we hear the resonant and majestic chanting of Vedic hymns with precise Sanskrit pronunciation, a display put on by Mīmāṃsā.

The Mīmāṃsā school is half grammarian and half judge for the Vedic scriptural authority. Known for its hermeneutical work in Indian philosophy, it offers a distinctive understanding of language and meaning, particularly concerning figurative language. It is considered that Mīmāṃsā has an enduring influence on other Indian traditions and various Buddhist schools.

2.1.1 Philosophical foundation of Mīmāṃsā

According to Bilimoria (2017), Mīmāṃsā is an influential school of classical Indian philosophy that originated from an ancient tradition of scriptural exegesis. Presupposing that all Vedic passages ultimately make sense, the school goes beyond mere exegesis of difficult Vedic passages by providing general rules of interpretation.

Epistemologically speaking, it aims to portray the Veda as the unquestioned source of knowledge regarding *dharma* (Bilimoria 2017).

2.1.2 Mīmāṃsā's understanding of language and meaning

Mīmāṃsā contends that the relationship between word and meaning is natural (*autpattika*), which commentators interpret as “non-human” (*apauruṣeya*) or “fixed” (*nitya*), implying that language is not something humans can influence. (Bilimoria 2017).

It argues for “the atemporal nature of words (*śabda*)” (Tzohar 2018, 29). Coupled with the notion of words having an atemporal nature prescribed by the atemporal nature of the Vedas, this invariable relation can only be fulfilled if the referent is also fixed and unchanging.

When it comes to the referent of words (Tzohar 2018), the aforementioned concept of fixity was achieved by Mīmāṃsā through interpreting the referents of single expressions (e.g., “cow”) as the abstract generic property or class property (cowness), rather than the individual

substance. This culminates in a substantivist ontology where words refer to real, existent entities (Tzohar 2018).

Furthermore, the school features a monosemic referential scheme (Tzohar 2018). The requirement for a decisive and consistent interpretation of the Vedas necessitates a monosemic referential scheme, meaning a word should not have different referents at different times.

2.1.3 Mīmāṃsā's understanding of *upacāra*

Given that Vedic injunctions often refer to specific individuals, Mīmāṃsā proposes that while the generic property is the primary referent, a word refers to the individual only metaphorically. This allows it to account for both the fixed semantic relations and the comprehension of individuals in ordinary language. This view means that “figurative transference becomes more the norm than the exception for Mīmāṃsa, particularly concerning the denotation of individuals” (Tzohar 2018, 30-31).

The referential mechanism of the Mīmāṃsā school is summarised as the absence of the primary referent in the locus of reference (Tzohar 2018). For example, in the phrase “to sacrifice the cow”, the noun “cow” is expected to directly refer to the generic property “cowness”, with reference to an individual “cow” only metaphorically. Formulaically framed, the primary referent “the generic property of cowness” is absent from the locus of reference “the individual cow” for the phrase “to sacrifice the cow”.

However, a question can be raised: can the generic property and individuality truly be separated? The Nyāya school offers a different answer.

2.2 Nyāya school

Continuing down the path, we are greeted by a measured voice of rigorous debate and precise questioning.

The Nyāya school is the pioneer of logico-epistemology. It is a significant system of classical Indian philosophy, primarily known for its focus on knowledge, the means to knowledge (*pramāṇa*), and the proper procedures for debate and critical enquiry (Bilimoria 2017).

2.2.1 Philosophical foundation

Fundamentally committed to realism, Nyāya holds the metaphysical thesis that things are what they are independently of our knowings and perceivings (Bilimoria 2017). This contrasts with Buddhist idealism.

Nyāya philosophers assert that consciousness is a contingent property of the immaterial self (*ātman*), not of the physical body. Against Buddhist no-self views, Nyāya argues for the existence of a diachronically unitary and persistent subject of cognitions. It is also known for its rational theology, specifically for establishing the existence of an omniscient Creator (Bilimoria 2017).

2.2.2 Nyāya's understanding of language and meaning

Like Mīmāṃsā, Nyāya subscribes to a substantivist ontology, holding that words refer to real, existent entities (Tzohar 2018).

The *Nyāya-sūtra* investigates the referent of a particular noun, such as “cow” (Tzohar 2018). Different from the Mīmāṃsā school, Nyāya argues that “a word refers to the individual and the generic property as inseparable elements” (Tzohar 2018, 35). The context of usage determines which element is principal and which is subordinate, which I call “meaning potentiality to be actualised”. Nyāya claims that “meaningful language requires the possibility of abstraction”, indicating that the individuality and generic property cannot be separated (Tzohar 2018, 35-36).

2.2.3 Nyāya's understanding of *upacāra*

Nyāya's definition of metaphorical expression is designed to align with the actual use of figures in ordinary language and with the school's realism. This contrasts with the Mīmāṃsā, which “saw much of ordinary language as metaphorical (referring to the individual metaphorically) due to its hermeneutical concerns” (Tzohar 2018, 41).

Nyāya's view closely parallels traditional rhetorical analysis of figurative devices. Its understanding of *upacāra* (metaphor) focuses on “the referential mechanism underlying

figurative (metaphorical) usage” (Tzohar 2018, 41). A key feature common to Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā is the understanding of figurative use in terms of the formula: the absence of the primary referent from the locus of reference. Yet Nyāya adopts a different perspective. For example, in the phrase “the boy is a lion”, the primary referent “lion” is absent from the locus of reference “the boy”. Nyāya interprets this absence as “nonactuality” (Tzohar 2018, 208). This “nonactuality” allows for the abstraction (e.g., bravery associated with a lion) to be applied to the individual (the boy), without denying the reality of either the boy or the general concept of a lion. Thus, the meaning potentiality of “lion” is actualised through abstraction, guided by the assessment of what is actual and what is not.

While Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā share a substantivist ontology, maintaining that words refer to real, existent entities, another mysterious figure chooses to bypass the issue of whether such entities truly exist.

2.3 Grammarian school: Bhartṛhari

Venturing deeper into the forest, we arrive at a pond. At its edge sits a grammarian, gazing at his own reflection in the ripples and reciting Sanskrit grammar rules for spiritual purification.

The Grammarian school, particularly associated with figures such as Bhartṛhari and Patañjali, played a significant role in classical Indian philosophy, chiefly through its sophisticated philosophy of language and its relationship with cognition and reality (Bilimoria 2017). This section focuses on Bhartṛhari, the spiritual grammarian examined by Tzohar (2018).

2.3.1 Bhartṛhari’s understanding of language

Bhartṛhari’s central thesis, famously articulated in the *Vākyapadīya*, is that all cognition (*jñāna*) appears to be penetrated by language. He contends that there is no concept in the world that does not conform to, or is not accompanied by, language (Bilimoria 2017).

He extends this concept to the subtle operations of language beneath surface consciousness, referring to an “unaware” state in which language-seeds remain active even during sleep. These language-seeds are stored impressions that enable vivid recollection (Bilimoria 2017).

Bhartṛhari integrates the grammatical tradition with the *Brahma-sūtra*'s inquiry into Brahman, describing Brahman as possessing Word (*śabda*) as its essence. He regards Word as an eternal creative principle, beyond human agency, that shapes phenomenal reality according to its own inherent structure (Bilimoria 2017). For Bhartṛhari, grammar is the path to liberation whereby language is purified from gross to subtle forms.

2.3.2 Bhartṛhari's understanding of *upacāra*

Unlike earlier Grammarians like Yāska and Pāṇini, who primarily focused on the formal aspects of language and did not treat figurative meaning as a distinct topic, Bhartṛhari delves deeply into its linguistic and philosophical implications (Tzohar 2018). The hallmark of Bhartṛhari's understanding of metaphor is his mentalist point of view. In his *Vākyapadīya*, Bhartṛhari points out the redundancy of ontological externality for determining meaning.

His mentalist approach "takes meaning as being determined by whatever cognitive content arises through the word's denotative power, regardless of the ontological status of the referent" (Tzohar 2018, 50). By tackling the semantic difficulty of verb forms that imply "origination", e.g., "the sprout takes birth" (*jāyate 'ṅkuraḥ*), Bhartṛhari suggests the mental existence of the referent of a word (Tzohar 2018, 66). If the sprout already exists, it cannot be born, but if it does not exist, there is no referent for the verbal suffix expressive of the actor.

Bhartṛhari argues for the "figurative existence" (*upacāra-sattā*) of all the referents of words, yet elaborates little on this concept (Tzohar 2018). One way to interpret this claim is to view "figurative existence" as a provisional mental existence given to the referents of words (Tzohar 2018, 67). According to this interpretation, "words refer not to real existents, but merely to mental images" (Tzohar 2018, 67). In doing so, ontological externality is bypassed. This offers a ready solution to expressions that appear to be referenceless, such as "rabbit's horn" (Tzohar 2018, 67).

Another case in Tzohar (2018) worth mentioning is the negation of nouns. Given the assumption of mental existence, negation can no longer be understood as implying the external nonexistence of the object of negation. For instance, the expression non-Brahmin (*a-Brāhmaṇa*) refers to someone of the warrior class. For this case, the negation merely indicates the absence of the mental image of a brahmin from the locus of reference, which is the mental image of a warrior (Tzohar 2018).

Thus far, we have found ourselves at the doorway to the Pantheon of Yogācāra.

2.4 Madhyamaka

Unfortunately, at the doorway stands a monk, Ven. Nāgārjuna, performing a dazzling bubble show and inviting us to pause before stepping further.

Due to the absence of significant references to metaphor in Madhyamaka scriptures, Tzohar (2018) does not devote a separate section to the Madhyamaka perspective on metaphor. Nevertheless, the book contains scattered mentions of Madhyamaka responses to the metaphor theories of other schools. The following includes a summary of Madhyamaka's views in these discussions.

2.4.1 Madhyamaka's understanding of language

The Madhyamaka school is characterised by its radical conventionalism (Tzohar 2018), a point worth noting, as it is one of the arguments that Sthiramati seeks to refute.

Nāgārjuna contends that sentences proclaiming the existence or nonexistence of anything are conventions. These statements about worldly things lack truth-values and should be accepted or rejected based solely on convenience (Holder 2023). Nāgārjuna's argument for this position is rooted in his doctrine of emptiness. He argues that claims about existence or nonexistence could only be ultimately true or false if they pertained to things with determinate natures (*svabhāva* – intrinsic nature, or *parabhāva* – extrinsic nature). However, Nāgārjuna seeks to demonstrate that nothing has a determinate nature (Holder 2023).

Holder (2023) continues that this conventionalist reading connects to the Buddhist “two truths” doctrine, differentiating “obscurational truth” (*saṃvṛtisatya*) from “ultimate truth” (*paramārthasatya*). For Nāgārjuna, the obscurational truth is language full of the merely conventional existence and non-existence of worldly things, which can never describe the true nature of reality. The ultimate truth, though not describable by conventional language, can only be attained through it.

2.4.2 Debates with Yogācāra

For Sthiramati, the primary challenge posed by Madhyamaka's radical conventionalism was not its "alleged ontological nihilism *per se*", but the "threat to meaningfulness of salvific discourse" (Tzohar 2018, 157).

Sthiramati critiques Madhyamaka's conventionalism by arguing that "convention without a basis (*upādāna*) does not make sense" (Tzohar 2018, 173). He posits that for language to be meaningful and for conceptual differentiation to occur, there must be underlying "extralinguistic restricting conditions" or a "support", which he identifies with the transformations of consciousness (Tzohar 2018, 176), a notion to be discussed later.

Sthiramati views Madhyamaka's stance as leading to a total collapse of meaningful discourse and the ensuing pragmatic contradiction, effectively rendering their own discourse senseless (Tzohar 2018).

Madhyamaka, in turn, argues that any appeal to "an extranominal basis" is itself a product of discursive thought and that there is no justified reason to privilege consciousness as "the underlying causal principle" (Tzohar 2018, 174). Moreover, it might embrace this collapse of discourse as a further "indication of the self-referential nature of language use, and therefore of its emptiness" (Tzohar 2018, 176).

Fearing that both the Pantheon of Yogācāra and ourselves might burst like bubbles at any moment, we proceed into the building with heavy, hesitant footsteps.

2.5 Yogācāra prior to Sthiramati

As we make our way into the empty and luminous hall, a holographic history of the Yogācāra school, sponsored and projected by the GreatMind Tech, unfolds before our eyes.

The Yogācāra school of Indian Buddhism presented a distinctive and innovative theory of meaning, particularly regarding metaphorical language, as an important aspect of its philosophy (Tzohar 2018). This section focuses on the period presumably preceding Sthiramati and on the ideas considered foundational to his theory of metaphor.

2.5.1 Philosophical foundation

The tradition is primarily associated with Asaṅga and Vasubandhu, along with the more obscure Maitreya, who are considered its founders (Williams 2008). Key early texts include the *Samdhinirmocana-sūtra* and the *Yogācārabhūmi* (King 1994). The *Madhyāntavibhāgaśāstra* is also an early text associated with Maitreya (Keenan 1982). Asaṅga's systematic treatises include the *Abhidharma-samuccaya* and *Mahāyāna-saṃgraha*, while Vasubandhu's *Triṃśikā* and *Viṃśatikā* are also important early works that elaborate on Yogācāra doctrines (Bilimoria 2017).

Early Yogācāra developed a robust constructivist cognitive theory, especially concerning the role of consciousness in shaping reality (Bilimoria 2017). Its key doctrines and concepts include the storehouse consciousness (*ālaya-vijñāna*), cognition only (*vijñapti-mātra*), three natures (*trisvabhāva*), emptiness (of grasper and grasped), all of which play a role in early Yogācāra's theory of metaphor.

2.5.2 *Laṅkāvatārasūtra*'s contribution to *upacāra*

The *Laṅkāvatārasūtra* offers a significant and sophisticated understanding of metaphor (*upacāra*) within Buddhist thought, “most notably in its tenth chapter, the *Sagāthakaṃ*” (Tzohar 2018, 137). The text is notable for its engagement with the relationship between language and reality, viewing metaphor as deeply interconnected with the operations of consciousness.

The *Laṅkāvatārasūtra* grounds the notion of *upacāra* in “a causal description of the operation of consciousness” and “the construction of the external world” (Tzohar 2018, 138). The text uses the formulaic term “the metaphors of self and things” (*ātmadharmopacāra*), which also appears in Vasubandhu's *Triṃśikā* and Sthiramati's commentary, to describe the realm of metaphor as governing all subjective and objective phenomena (Tzohar 2018, 140).

The terms “self” and “things”¹ are considered metaphorical since “their primary referents are unreal”; “they are applied only in a secondary sense” (Tzohar 2018, 141). The actual referents of these figures are “the underlying causal reality that brings about the appearances of these unreal primary referents”. For the naïve, words seem to “denote real,

¹ “things” will be translated as “phenomena” later

independent entities (understood as their primary referents)”, but for the wise, they indirectly refer to “the interdependent causal reality that serves as the basis for the appearances of these alleged real entities” (Tzohar 2018, 141).

For example, verse 10.414 in *LAS* explicitly states that terms like “self” and “sense-faculties” are metaphors:

It is with respect to the three consciousnesses that I instruct the metaphors of self and sense faculties. However, the mind (*citta*), mental faculty (*manas*), and consciousness (*viññāna*) are without intrinsic identity. (*LAS* 10.414)²

It is interpreted by Tzohar (2018) that terms such as “self” and “sense-faculties” are metaphors when viewed in relation to the underlying causal mental reality.

Based on such observations, Tzohar (2018, 143) concludes that the *LAS* presents *upacāra* as a linguistic sign that simultaneously “indicates an absence and a presence”: “the ontological nonexistence and referential absence of an allegedly real (primary) object, and the presence of a causal deep-structure, which can be referred to only indirectly”.

2.5.3 Asaṅga’s contribution to *upacāra*

The Centre of Buddhist Studies and the University of Hong Kong are to me what Maitreya and Tuṣita Heaven were to Asaṅga.

As a key figure in early Yogācāra thought, Asaṅga made significant contributions to the philosophical understanding of the relationship between language and reality. His work, primarily found in early Yogācāra treatises, can be considered foundational for the school’s philosophy of language.

Asaṅga’s ideas concerning the relationship between language and reality are prominently featured in the *Tattvārthapaṭalaṃ* (*TApāṭ*) of the *Bodhisattvabhūmi* (*BBh*), one of the oldest

² *ātmendriyopacāraṃ hi tricitte deśayāmy aham/ cittam manas ca viññānaṃ svalakṣaṇavisamṃyuktā // LAS*
10.414 (Vaidya, 1963, 134)

Yogācāra treatises, and its accompanying sections in the *Viniścayasamgrahaṇī* (VS). Both texts are part of the broader *Yogācārabhūmi* (YB) corpus, traditionally ascribed to him (Tzohar 2018).

2.5.3.1 Critique of essentialist theories of meaning

One of Asaṅga's central aims is to demonstrate the inexpressibility of the true, essential nature of reality (*svabhāvatā*) through reasoning (Tzohar 2018, 77). He does this by highlighting the incoherence of any expressible essential nature (Tzohar 2018, 86):

If one may ask, by means of what reasoning is the inexpressible essential reality of all dharmas to be known? It is as follows: Whatever designation for the intrinsic identities (*svalakṣaṇa*) of things, such as “matter,” “sensation,” and all the other aggregates as mentioned before, up to “Nirvāṇa”—it should be understood as designation only (*prajñaptimātram*). It is not the essential nature [of these things] and there is no other object of speech or a sphere of an engagement of speech which is excluded from that.³

Asaṅga argues that the essentialist view implies a relationship between a thing and its designation that is invariable, exclusive, and monosemic, and he aims to undermine this premise (Tzohar 2018, 85).

Asaṅga introduces the possibility of a polysemy of figures, where various metaphors can denote the same object (Tzohar 2018, 95-96). For instance, to demonstrate the absurd consequences of an essentialist theory of meaning, he uses the stock *śāstric* examples of the figurative reference to a child as a “lion” (*siṃho māṇavakaḥ*) and also as “fire” (*agnir māṇavakaḥ*). This points out that if a single object, such as a child, could have multiple essences (childness, fireness, lionness) based on different designations, it would contradict the essentialist definition of a singular essence and undermine any criterion for the determination of meaning.

He uses the magical creation analogy, where “a magician who creates an illusory being and transforms it so that it appears as the bodies of various creatures” (Tzohar 2018, 106), to illustrate the point that an illusory being (referent) appears as various bodies (metaphors),

³ “*na svabhāvo nāpi ca tad vinirmuktas tad anyo vāggocaro vāgaviṣayaḥ . . .*” (Dutt, 1978, 30)

demonstrating the referential interchangeability of figures and undermining a monosemic word-world correspondence.

2.5.3.2 Perspectival view of experience

Asaṅga uses examples such as the varied perceptions of yogis to illustrate a perspectival view of experience, thereby undermining the notion of external, mind-independent objects as the sole referents of perception.

Many Yogins, through knowledge born by concentration on one object, apprehend a variety of visions (Tzohar 2018, 122; 203). This highlights that even when focusing on a single object, practitioners can perceive it differently, leading to a perspectival view of experience in the sense that enlightened and defiled minds perceive the same things differently.

Asaṅga contends that “the elimination of discursive thought by a bodhisattva applies only to their private experiential realm and does not annihilate the intersubjective realm, which is maintained by the shared karmic streams and discursive thought of unenlightened others” (Tzohar 2018, 202). This implies that the underlying mental causal processes for sentient beings and bodhisattvas should be different due to the elimination of discursive thought, contrary to Tzohar (2018)’s claim of the same underlying mental causal process as the basis for communication.

2.5.4 Vasubandhu’s contribution to *upacāra*

Thanks to the vivid projection by GreatMind, we can see Vasubandhu lecturing at Nalanda.

Vasubandhu’s understanding of metaphor (*upacāra*) is a significant aspect of early Yogācāra thought, particularly as expressed in his *Abhidharmakośabhāṣya* (AKBh) and *Triṃśikā* (*Triṃś*) (Tzohar 2018).

A hand is raised. A question is asked. A lively dialogue ensues.

The question asked is “Why are hunger and thirst tangible things?”

2.5.4.1 Hunger, thirst and happiness

Vasubandhu defines the eleven “tangibles” (*spraṣṭavya*), among which “hunger” and “thirst” are included, noting that these are to be understood as merely figurative terms (Tzohar 2018, 129):

Eleven things are tangible things: the four primary elements, softness, hardness, weight, lightness, cold, hunger, and thirst. The elements will be explained below ... “Hunger” is what produces desire for food; “thirst” is what produces a desire for drinking. In fact, the tangible which produces hunger and thirst is designated by the word “hunger”: the cause is designated by the name of the effect. In the same way that it is said “The appearance of the Buddha is happiness; the teaching of the religion is happiness; happiness, the harmony of the community; happiness, the austerities of monks who are in agreement.” (*AKBh* 1.10., La Vallée Poussin, 1988, 384)⁴

Vasubandhu clarifies that “hunger” is what produces desire for food, and “thirst” is what produces a desire for drinking. In his view, the tangible phenomenon that produces hunger and thirst is actually designated by the word “hunger”. This is an example of the metonymic formula where “the cause is designated by the name of the effect” (*kāraṇe kāryopacārāt*) (Tzohar 2018, 131). This metonymic reading provides a hermeneutical solution to the occurrence of hunger and thirst amongst tangible things. In the same way, “The appearance of the Buddha is happiness” is interpreted as the appearance of the Buddha is the cause of happiness. It is argued in Tzohar (2018) that metaphor or metonymy is largely a hermeneutical device for Vasubandhu.

2.5.4.2 Intersubjective agreement

In the *Viṃśikākārikā*, Vasubandhu presents the *pretas* example as a response to the objection that if the phenomenal world “consists only of mental impressions” (Tzohar 2018, 193), then it would be impossible to explain intersubjective agreement, i.e., how different perceivers have similar experiences. *Pretas* are described in Buddhist cosmology as beings who, due to past

⁴ *spraṣṭavyam ekādaśadravyasvabhāvam—catvāri mahābhūtāni, ślakṣṇatvam, karkaśatvam, gurutvam, laghutvam, śītam, jighatsā, pipāsā ceti| tatra bhūtāni paścād vakṣyāmaḥ | . . . jighatsā bhojanābhilāṣakṛt| kāraṇe kāryopacārāt| yathā—buddhānām sukha utpādaḥ sukhā dharmasya deśanā | sukhā saṅghasya sāmagrī samagrāṇām tapaḥ sukham* (Pradhan, 1975, 7).

karma driven by lust and greed, suffer from unquenched hunger and thirst. Vasubandhu states that these *pretas* have shared visions of “rivers of pus and filth” guarded by violent figures (Tzohar 2018, 193).

These shared visions are imagined by the *pretas*. Where humans see rivers of clear water, *pretas* see pus and filth. This discrepancy attests to the unreality of the content of the *pretas*’ shared experience. This example demonstrates that intersubjective agreement is possible even with respect to nonexistent objects (Tzohar 2018).

The *pretas* example challenges the realist view of mind-independent reality and accounts for experiential discrepancies between different groups of perceivers (clear water for humans; pus and filth for *pretas*).

Vasubandhu’s discussion of intersubjectivity contributes to Sthiramati’s development of Yogācāra’s theory of discourse understanding.

2.6 Sthiramati’s pan-metaphorism

In the predawn hush of Nalanda, Sthiramati sits cross-legged, contemplating the harmony and tension between the views of his predecessors.

O Sthiramati! The Yogācāra’s jewel, you polished bright; unravelling thought with clarity and light.

Sthiramati, a highly influential Yogācāra philosopher in 6th-century India, is primarily renowned for his extensive commentarial work on early Yogācāra treatises and sūtras. Despite the commentarial nature of his writings, close readings reveal him to be a highly sophisticated and innovative thinker in his own right, offering original insights that were instrumental in consolidating the distinct identity of the Yogācāra school (Tzohar 2018).

2.6.1 Sthiramati as Yogācāra synthesiser and innovator

Sthiramati operated with a more defined understanding of Yogācāra as a distinct school or textual tradition compared to his predecessors, such as Asaṅga and Vasubandhu (Tzohar and Kramer 2022). His main interpretive challenge was to synthesise a varied collection of texts

into a coherent worldview. He accomplished this by integrating ideas from both Buddhist and non-Buddhist thinkers, weaving them into a novel philosophical synthesis.

Sthiramati consistently presupposed the eight-consciousness scheme grouped into three layers, i.e., “manifest forms of mind”, “defiled mind”, and “store mind”, in his *Triṃśikābhāṣya* and *Pañcaskandhakavibhāṣā* (Tzohar and Kramer 2022).

A key area of his innovation is his unique interpretation of the three natures. While the standard interpretation in Yogācāra often presents the dependent nature as ultimately existent, which is the substratum of reality, Sthiramati’s approach significantly deviates (D’AMATO 2005). Unlike the standard interpretation, Sthiramati’s view does not ultimately affirm the existence of the dependent nature. He explicitly states that “the dependent characteristic does not ultimately exist” (D’AMATO 2005). For Sthiramati, the dependent nature is categorised with the imagined nature as a phenomenal or conventional aspect of reality. He argues that the dependent nature is “to be abandoned” and that thorough knowledge of the three natures brings about its “termination” or “destruction”. This would be unreasonable if it were the ultimate substratum of reality (D’AMATO 2005). According to Sthiramati, only the perfected nature is ultimately existent (D’AMATO 2005). He equates the perfected characteristic with “thusness” (*tathatā*), which is a crucial term for ultimate reality in his texts. The perfected nature is described as “naturally purified” (*prakṛtyā viśuddha*) from defilements and is ultimately existent (*paramavidyamānatā*) (D’AMATO 2005).

2.6.2 Main points of Sthiramati’s pan-metaphorism

Now comes the climax of our journey.

It is now easier to understand the final reconstruction of Sthiramati’s pan-metaphorism by Tzohar (2018) and my critical review of it in light of all that we have explored thus far. This dissertation contends that it is more favourable to treat Sthiramati’s theory within the continuum of the overarching Yogācāra framework, along with his predecessors, than to make it singularly prominent. The dissertation holds that all Yogācāra thinkers and works contribute to a Yogācāra grammar of metaphor. For the sake of convenience, I have followed Tzohar’s terminology thus far.

2.6.2.1 Basis for pan-metaphorical claim

According to Tzohar (2018), the gist of Sthiramati's analysis of metaphor is found in his commentary on the first verse of the *Trīṃś*. From this section on, I will provide my own translation, attempting to be more literal than Tzohar's translation while practising my Sanskrit:

Indeed, the manifold metaphor of self (*ātman*) and phenomena (*dharma*) that occur, with “in the world and in the scriptures” being the remaining part of the sentence, this is in the transformation of consciousness.⁵

From this overarching philosophical view of Sthiramati is the pan-metaphorical claim derived by Tzohar (2018). This dissertation assumes from this claim that all metaphors can be traced to a root metaphor (√metaphor) with the interplay between the non-existent self (*ātman*) and phenomena (*dharma*) as its soil. In this verse, *ātmadharmopacāra*, *lokaśāstrau* and *viññānapariṇāmaḥ* are concepts of particular significance and merit close attention.

2.6.2.2 Adoption of *śāstric* formula

Below is my translation of the verses quoted by Tzohar (2018, 158):

These two kinds of metaphorical designations are only in the transformation of consciousness, not in a primary self or in phenomena. Whence this? Because phenomena and the self do not exist outside the transformation of consciousness.⁶

As is shown by the verses, Sthiramati adopts the *śāstric* formula of metaphor, which states that a word is used metaphorically when its primary referent is absent from its locus of reference. Sthiramati integrates this definition with the fundamental Yogācāra assumption that “all objectified phenomena do not exist as they appear” (Tzohar 2018, 161).

⁵ *ātmadharmopacāro hi vividho yaḥ pravartate | lokaśāstrayor iti vākyaśeṣaḥ | viññānapariṇāme 'sau* (Buescher, 2007, 43; Tzohar 2018, 157).

⁶ *ayaṃ dviprakāro 'py upacāro viññānapariṇāma eva na mukhye ātmani dharmeṣu ceti | kuta etat | dharmāṇām ātmanaś ca viññānapariṇāmād bahir abhāvāt* (Tzohar 2018, 159)

2.6.2.3 Transformation of consciousness

Then, what is “the transformation of consciousness”?

“Transformation of consciousness” in this context is not understood as the transformation of consciousness into wisdom:

What is this so-called transformation? It is otherness.⁷

“Otherness” here is interpreted by Tzohar (2018, 158) as “the state of being otherwise than what it previously was”. The verses continue to elaborate on the transformation of consciousness:

Transformation is the arising of an effect, distinct from the causal moment and simultaneous with the cessation of the causal moment. There, from the *ālaya-vijñāna*, due to the maturation of latent impressions through conceptualising self, etc., and through conceptualising form, etc., arises conceptualisation appearing as self, etc., and appearing as form, etc.⁸

It can be inferred from the above verses that the transformation of consciousness can be understood as the interplay between different layers of consciousness, called “underlying mental causal process” by Tzohar (2018), that gives rise to the construction of the notion of “self” and “form”.

2.6.2.4 Ontological nonexistence and referential absence

Sthiramati’s grand exposition continues to unfold:

Taking that appearance of self, etc., and appearance of form, etc., as if external to that conceptualisation, the metaphorical designation of self, etc., and the metaphorical designation of phenomena such as form, etc., proceed from

⁷ ko 'yaṃpariṇāmo nāma|anyathātvam| (Tzohar 2018, 159)

⁸ kāraṇakṣaṇanīrodhasamakālah kāraṇakṣaṇavilakṣaṇaḥ kāryasyātmalābhaḥ pariṇāmaḥ | tatr ātmādivikalpavāsanāparipoṣād rūpādivikalpavāsanāparipoṣāc cālayavijñānād ātmādinirbhāso vikalpo rūpādinirbhāsaś cotpadyate | (Tzohar 2018, 159)

beginningless time, even without an external self and phenomena... And what does not exist somewhere, that is metaphorically designated there.⁹

Sthiramati's identification of the referential absence with ontological nonexistence is a crucial step in his argument. In the Yogācāra view, apparent objects such as the “self” and “phenomena” are ultimately unreal or nonexistent in the way they are conventionally perceived, with their supposed primary referents always absent in reality.

2.6.2.5 *Upādāna*: basis for transformation of consciousness

Let's recall ourselves to the discussion about Madhyama in § 2.4.

Madhyamaka holds that statements about existence or nonexistence are purely conventional and language and statements should be accepted or rejected based on their practical convenience, not on their correspondence to an ultimate reality.

Sthiramati's main criticism of Madhyamaka is that its radical conventionalism undermines the very possibility of meaningful and salvific discourse. He argues that conventions, including language, require an underlying basis (*upādāna*). Now let the eloquence of Sthiramati be felt:

And since a baseless metaphorical expression is impossible, one must necessarily accept that a transformation of consciousness actually exists, upon which the metaphorical expressions of self and phenomena are based... Thus, all objects of cognition do not ultimately exist because they are conceptually constructed, but consciousness exists substantially because it is dependently arisen.¹⁰

Sthiramati ties together the concept of *upacāra* (metaphor), the nonexistence of objectified phenomena, and the transformation of consciousness, termed “underlying causal reality” by

⁹ *tam ātmādinirbhāsaṃ rūpādinirbhāsaṃ ca tasmād vikalpād bahirbhūtam ivopādāyātmādyupacāro rūpādidharmopacāraś cānādikālikah pravartate vināpi bāhyenātmanā dharmaiś ca |...| yac ca yatra nāsti tat tatropacaryate* | (Tzohar 2018, 159)

¹⁰ *upacārasya ca nirādhārasyāsaṃbhavād avaśyaṃ vijñānapariṇāmo vastuto 'stīty upagantavyo yatrātmadharmopacārah pravartate | ...| evaṃ ca sarvaṃ vijñeyaṃ parikalpitasvabhāvatvād vastuto na vidyate vijñānaṃ punaḥ pratītyasamutpannatvād dravyato 'stīty abhyupeyam* | (Tzohar 2018, 159)

Tzohar (2018). According to Tzohar’s (2018) interpretation, Sthiramati identifies the true locus of reference for these metaphorical designations with the underlying mental causal process, namely, the “transformations of consciousness” (*viññāna-pariṇāma*). Language, therefore, metaphorically refers to this dynamic, causal activity of the mind, rather than to stable, independent entities, which are nonexistent.

2.6.2.6 Elimination of qualitative similarity

Sthiramati refines the traditional definition of metaphor by eliminating the necessity for qualitative similarity between the primary and secondary referents in the traditional view of metaphor. For instance, in “The child is fire.”, the primary referent of “fire” is burning that produces light and heat, while here it functions as the secondary referent, which is the child.

Sthiramati argues that the association between “the child” and “fire” is superimposed as we “sometimes think of a boy without thinking of fire” (Tzohar 2018, 163):

Since sharpness and yellowness are observed in the boy even in the absence of the universal essence of fire, invariable concomitance is inappropriate. If there were invariable concomitance, there would be no metaphorical expression, because the universal would exist in the boy just as in fire.¹¹

As is noted by Tzohar (2018, 149), Sthiramati reduces metaphor to its “bare minimum”, the mere absence of the primary referent (self and phenomena) from the locus of reference. This reduction is consistent with the Yogācāra view that all phenomena are mental representations. This bare definition allows the concept of metaphor to be applied conceptually, even to words typically considered literal. As indicated by the above example, both “child” and “fire” share the same status of being metaphors from a Yogācāra perspective.

¹¹ *jātyabhāve 'pi tīkṣṇatvakapilatvayor māṇavake darśanād avinābhāvitvam ayuktam | avinābhāvitve copacārābhāvo 'gnāv iva māṇavake 'pi jātisadbhāvāt | tasmān na māṇavake jātyupacāraḥ sambhavati |* (Tzohar 2018, 163)

2.6.2.7 Pan-metaphorism under three-natures scheme

Sthiramati's ingenuity lies in explicitly tying the three natures to his "pan-metaphorical claim" that all language use is metaphorical (Tzohar 2018).

Sthiramati elucidates the nature of the transformation of consciousness by linking it to "conceptual construction" or "discursive thinking" (*vikalpa*), which is directly associated with the imagined nature within the three natures scheme. He explains in his commentary on *Triṃśikā* verse:

Thus, this threefold transformation of consciousness that has just been explained is discursive thinking (*vikalpa*). "Discursive thinking" is defined as the mind and mental factors of the three realms whose objects appear in the form of superimposed characteristics.¹²

To summarise the series of Sthiramati's argumentation in simple terms, the imagined nature refers to entities or phenomena as they appear to be essentially and independently existent, and are conventionally designated by names and concepts. It is the product of conceptual construction or discursive thinking (*vikalpa*) and is ultimately non-existent in the way it appears. For example, the "self" and "phenomena" as objectively existing entities fall under this nature.

The dependent nature is the underlying mental causal process that brings about the appearance of the imagined nature. It is identified with the "transformation of consciousness" (*viññāna-pariṇāma*) and the Buddhist notion of dependent arising (*pratītya-samutpāda*) (Tzohar 2018, 160). The dependent nature is said to "arise from causes" and is the actual referential basis of conventional terms, even if words refer to it metaphorically (Tzohar 2018, 141). It is "the causal nexus" through which discursive thinking operates and brings about phenomena (Tzohar 2018, 181).

The perfected nature is the dependent nature "when it is entirely freed from the imagined" (Tzohar 2018, 181). It represents the reality of phenomena as they are, free from the dualistic conceptualisations (such as grasper and grasped) that characterise the imagined nature.

¹² *iti | yo 'yaṃ vijñānapariṇāmas trividho 'nantaram abhīhitaḥ so 'yaṃ vikalpaḥ | adhyāropitārthākārās traidhātukāś cittacaitā vikalpa ucyate ||* (Tzohar 2018, 161)

It becomes increasingly clear that, for Sthiramati or Yogācāra, *upacāra* (metaphor) is not merely a rhetorical device but “the linguistic expression of the three natures scheme” (Tzohar 2018). It simultaneously indicates the ontological nonexistence and referential absence of the imagined (primary) object, and the presence of the causal deep-structure (dependent nature), which can only be referred to indirectly.

The meaning of a term is understood by Tzohar (2018) as constituted by the description of an underlying causal process. This means that while words referring to phenomena as inherently existing (imagined nature) are metaphorically used because their primary referents are absent, they actually refer to the transformations of consciousness, a dependently arisen mechanism, as their “referential pole” (locus of reference) (Tzohar 2018, 174).

2.6.2.8 Hierarchy of meaning

From the above scheme in relation to the three natures which reflects the dynamism of a dependently arisen mechanism, Tzohar (2018, 170) extrapolates that the meaning of a term is constituted by the description of an underlying causal process, and these descriptions are “dynamic”, increasing in intricacy and subtlety.

This leads to a hierarchically organised understanding where some speakers’ causal descriptions are more accurate and thus more “meaningful” (Tzohar 2018, 170). For example, “a simpleton” might understand “self” as an objectively existing entity, while an advanced bodhisattva understands it as “the evolving activity of the eight modes of consciousness”, eventually leading to exhaustive direct knowledge of causal relations. Coincidentally, reading Tzohar (2018) is also a process of hierarchical understanding. The first time I read this book, I had little background in Buddhist studies, thinking that its topic was really cool. The second time, I grasped the general ideas of the book. By the third reading, I felt that the author’s analysis was not entirely accurate, and it might not be a cool topic for writing a dissertation.

Additionally, Sthiramati’s commentary on Asanga’s *Abhidharmasamuccaya* (*AS*) also suggests a hierarchical meaning construction. It is mentioned in Tzohar (2018, 211) that those who are inclined towards the literal cannot grasp Mahāyāna doctrines because these doctrines are expressed via the Buddha’s “implicit meaning”, insinuating a possibility of different levels of understanding for different groups of audiences.

It should be noted that Tzohar (2018) here returns to the traditional rhetorical understanding of metaphor, deviating from the notion of metaphor on the conceptual level within Yogācāra philosophy.

2.6.2.9 Solution to incommensurability by Tzohar (2018)

The problem of incommensurability in Buddhist tradition is how beings at vastly different stages of the Buddhist path can engage in meaningful conversation despite the significant “epistemic differences” separating them (Tzohar 2018, 178-179).

This is particularly pertinent for the Mahāyāna conception of a bodhisattva, who, though enlightened, must operate and communicate “within *samsāra*”. This situation necessitates that conventional discourse remain meaningful while accommodating deeply discrepant modes of language use for “salvific efficacy” (Tzohar 2018, 179).

This issue is also discussed in the Yogācāra lore in terms of “how to bridge the bodhisattva’s nonconceptual (*nirvikalpa*) experience of reality on the one hand and his use of ordinary language within the realm of *samsāra* on the other” (Tzohar 2018, 179). To this end, various Yogācāra thinkers introduce “a division of labour between two types of knowledge”: “nondiscriminatory awareness” (*nirvikalpajñāna*), and the “awareness obtained subsequent to it” (*tatprṣṭhalabdhajñāna*) (Tzohar 2018, 179).

As stated by Tzohar (2018), nonconceptual awareness is inherently ineffable, free of constructions, and precludes intentional content or communication. It is considered a core experience of the bodhisattva but is not the endpoint of spiritual development; rather, it is a mediatory stage.

Sthiramati views the “awareness obtained subsequent to it” (*tatprṣṭhalabdhajñāna*) as a “subsequent mundane pure awareness” (*tatprṣṭhalabdhasuddhalaikajñāna*) that follows a bodhisattva’s “nonconceptual awareness” (Tzohar 2018, 182), which allows for the conceptualisation of the dependent as an object of knowledge:

Since the dependent nature is knowable only through the mundane pure wisdom obtained after seeing that transcendent wisdom, as long as the perfect nature, which is seen by non-conceptual transcendent wisdom, is not seen, not penetrated, and not directly realised, it is not apprehended by any other

knowledge. Since the dependent nature is knowable only through the mundane pure wisdom obtained after seeing transcendent wisdom, as long as the perfect nature, which is seen by non-conceptual transcendent wisdom, is not seen, not penetrated, not directly realised, it is not apprehended by any other knowledge. Therefore, as long as the perfect nature is not seen, the dependent nature is not seen.¹³

To discuss effectively the problem of incommensurability based on the above evidence, Tzohar (2018) proposes that the underlying mental causal process serves as the fixed common referent for beings at vastly different stages of the Buddhist path. Simply put, the shared underlying mental causal process provides the common ground for communication between a simpleton and a bodhisattva.

This framework is claimed by Tzohar (2018) to allow for different modes of language use to be layered in accordance with their respective knowledge of causality. The reference of a term remains fixed across different speakers because each speaker, the term, and its referent are linked via a causal mental description. However, the variance in meaning between speakers arises from the discrepancies in their knowledge of these respective causal mental descriptions.

This is to me the most controversial part of Tzohar's (2018) reconstruction. As demonstrated by the previous analysis, the underlying mental causal processes between a simpleton and a bodhisattva are by no means the same.

From the perspective of the three natures scheme, the underlying mental causal process of a simpleton should be full of imagined nature, while that of a bodhisattva perfected nature.

From the perspective of the complexity of the underlying mental causal process, a bodhisattva's mental causal process is two-fold, consisting of "nondiscriminatory awareness" (*nirvikalpajñāna*), and the "awareness obtained subsequent to it" (*tatprṣṭhalabdhajñāna*), whereas the simpleton's is truly simplistic.

¹³ *nirvikalpalokottarajñānadṛśye pariniṣpanne svabhāve adṛṣṭe apratividdhe asākṣātkṛte tatprṣṭha labdhasūddhalaukikajñānagamyatvāt paratanthro 'nyena jñānena na gṛhyate | ataḥ pariniṣpanne 'dṛṣṭe paratanthro na dṛśyate* | (Tzohar 2018, 182)

2.6.2.10 Solution to incommensurability by this dissertation

This dissertation proposes the idea of “the inter-accessible point of inference” in light of *pramāṇa* as an alternative way to explain how a bodhisattva and a simpleton communicate.

The direct perception of a bodhisattva is the present state of having attained enlightenment. On the basis of this direct perception, an inference is made by a bodhisattva that other beings can also attain enlightenment as the bodhisattva him- or herself has done.

The direct perception of a simpleton is knowing the fact that someone has become a bodhisattva. On the basis of this direct perception, an inference is made by a simpleton that the simpleton him- or herself can also attain enlightenment as a bodhisattva has done.

Based on the inferences made from the two directions arises the inter-accessible point of inference, as shown by the diagram below:

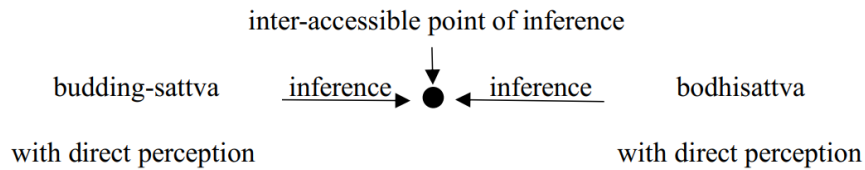


Figure 1 – Inter-accessible point of inference¹⁴.

This dissertation holds that a simpleton and a bodhisattva have different underlying mental causal processes. The effective communication between the two parties lies in the inter-accessible point of inference as a dependently co-arisen common ground, which also applies to the interpretation of salvific discourse. In this way, the Yogācāra model of meaning can distinguish itself from Bhartṛhari’s concept of “mental image” discussed in §2.3.

¹⁴ ‘budding’ here means being in early stage

2.6.2.11 Case study

The conclusion of Tzohar (2018) presents a case analysis focused on the role and meaning of lists or clusters of figures (similes and metaphors) that are widely found in Mahāyāna literature and associated Yogācāra works.

Asaṅga's MS 2.26, 27 is concerned with "a list of figures describing the dependent nature" (Tzohar 2018, 209):

How should one understand the other-dependent pattern? It should be understood through the teaching on such similes as a magic trick, a mirage, a dream trace, a shadow, a reflection, a valley echo, the moon in water, a transformation . . . (Keenan, 1992, 51–52)

Tzohar (2018) argues for a performative aspect of these figures. To fully understand their function, one must consider what such lists "do" in different contexts, not just "what they say" (Tzohar 2018, 212).

Tzohar (2018, 216) claims that the performative function of the multiplicity and interchangeability of figures in the lists is to expose the "ungrounded nature" of both the description (language) and what it purports to describe (referent).

Imagine trying to describe the taste of a complex dish using only ingredients. You could list every single ingredient and describe how they interact, building a vivid picture in the mind's eye (the dependent nature and its causal descriptions). But no matter how detailed your description, it could never be the actual taste (the perfected nature). The act of continuously listing and associating ingredients is not just informative but also performative. It highlights the inherent limitations of words to convey direct experience, yet paradoxically, it is the only way to guide someone towards an understanding that transcends the mere list.

Such an analysis is impressive yet somewhat reverts again to the metaphor in the traditional rhetorical sense. An important aspect of Sthiramati's pan-metaphorism is his reduction of metaphor to the conceptual level, that is to say "a magic trick, a mirage, a dream trace, a shadow, a reflection, a valley echo, the moon in water, a transformation" are metaphors, but more importantly, so is the term "the other-dependent pattern" metaphorical. However, Tzohar's (2018) case study falls short of expounding why the term "the other-dependent pattern" is also metaphorical on the conceptual level within the Yogācāra model of meaning.

2.7 Yogācāra grammar of metaphor

This section is a *nirmita-nagara*, where we can take a moment to rest, while reviewing what we have achieved and setting later objectives.

2.7.1 Differentiating two metaphors

As demonstrated in the preceding analysis, it is important to differentiate between two types of metaphor in the context of Yogācāra's understanding of metaphor.

One is the metaphor understood from a traditional rhetorical perspective. In the expression “The boy is a lion.”, “a lion” acts as a metaphor for “the boy”, a usage with which we are all familiar.

The other is the metaphor in conceptual terms. Within Yogācāra philosophy, both “the boy” and “a lion” are metaphorical in the sense that the primary referents are ontologically nonexistent. Language refers metaphorically to an underlying mental causal process.

We should be careful not to blur the boundary between the two kinds of metaphor when engaging with Yogācāra philosophy.

2.7.2 Formula

The root formula is framed as: “the primary referent of a word is absent from its locus of reference”, while the formula derived for Yogācāra is: “the primary referent of a word (ontological existence) is absent from its locus of reference (the underlying mental causal process)”.

2.7.3 Basis for reference

It is asserted by Tzohar (2018) that the basis for reference for all language is the underlying mental causal process, identified as the “transformations of consciousness” (*viññāna-pariṇāma*).

2.7.4 Basis for shared and different perceptions

The arising of the “sentient and insentient receptacle world” (*sattva-bhājana-loka*) is attributed to the accumulated actions (*karma*) of its beings. Karma is distinguished into common (*sādhāraṇa*) and noncommon (*asādhāraṇa*) action (Tzohar 2018, 121).

According to Tzohar (2018, 121), shared nonvolitional karma regulates and affects what is experienced as an independent and external intersubjective world, including mutual vision (the fact that people see one another). Special volitional karma is responsible for creating the animate and mostly privately experienced realm.

2.7.5 Basis for communication between groups of different levels of attainment

Tzohar (2018) argues for a fixed, shared underlying mental causal process as the common ground for communication between a simpleton and a bodhisattva. Even the use of the term “fixed” does not fit into a Buddhist context. To argue against Tzohar’s (2018) position, this dissertation proposes “the inter-accessible point of inference” as the basis for effective communication between different groups of beings.

2.7.6 Arguing against Mīmāṃsā

While both Yogācāra and Mīmāṃsā employ the concept of *upacāra* and understand it in terms of the absence of a primary referent from the locus of reference, their fundamental philosophical motivations and conclusions diverge significantly.

Mīmāṃsā anchors meaning in a substantivist ontology where words refer to real, existent generic properties. Yogācāra, conversely, asserts that all perceived objects are unreal fabrications, and language refers to nonexistent entities, grounding meaning instead in mental causal processes.

For Mīmāṃsā, the metaphorical use applies when referring to individuals, as the primary referent is always the generic property. For Yogācāra, all language is inherently metaphorical because its apparent referents (e.g., “self” and “phenomena” as real entities) are fundamentally nonexistent.

Mīmāṃsā's use of figurative language serves hermeneutical ends, maintaining a fixed semantic system for Vedic interpretation. Yogācāra's pan-metaphorical claim aims to legitimise Yogācāra's metaphysical discourse.

2.7.7 Arguing against Nyāya

Both Yogācāra and the Nyāya school define metaphor as the “absence of the primary referent from the locus of reference”. However, Nyāya interprets this absence as “nonactuality”. For instance, when “a boy is fire”, a literal fire is absent from the boy. Yogācāra, on the other hand, identifies this absence with ontological nonexistence, leading to the radical pan-metaphorical claim.

Nyāya's theory is also firmly rooted in a substantivist ontology where words ultimately refer to real, existent entities. Yogācāra's theory, however, operates from a non-realist stance, asserting that all perceived objects are unreal fabrications. For Yogācāra, language refers to nonexistent entities, and its true “locus of reference” is the internal, mental causal process of consciousness.

For Nyāya, metaphor is a specific linguistic tool used when the primary, literal referent is absent but there is a qualitative similarity to an existent entity. It is an exception or a secondary mode of meaning that helps align language with realism. For Yogācāra, the entirety of language is inherently metaphorical because its apparent referents (e.g., “self” and “phenomena” as real entities) are fundamentally nonexistent. This essentially collapses the distinction between primary and secondary meaning when applied to real external entities.

Nyāya's *upacāra* theory aims to uphold the realism and common-sense understanding of language in the world. Yogācāra's pan-metaphorism, conversely, aims to undermine naïve realism about language, demonstrating that words do not correspond to external, inherently existing entities.

2.7.8 Arguing against Bhartṛhari

Both Yogācāra and Bhartṛhari offer significant and philosophically innovative treatments of *upacāra*, using it as a central concept in their theories of meaning. For Yogācāra, its theory of meaning is “indebted to Bhartṛhari's account of this topic” (Tzohar 2018, 42).

Both Bhartṛhari and Yogācāra put forth a “pan-metaphorical” claim that all language use is metaphorical. Bhartṛhari argues for a “figurative existence” (*upacārasattā*) for all referents of words. Yogācāra explicitly states that “all language use, ‘in the world and in treatises’, is metaphorical” (Tzohar 2018, 154).

Both sides challenge the idea that language directly corresponds to an external, inherently existing reality. A core motivation for both is the need to explain how language can remain meaningful and operative without appealing to an external, objective, ontological grounding for its referents.

Bhartṛhari’s mentalist position understands meaning as whatever cognitive content arises from a word’s denotative power, “regardless of the ontological status of the referent” (Tzohar 2018, 62). It can be inferred from his philosophical background discussed in § 2.3 that his “mental image” is likely to be *a priori* knowledge due to his brahmanical background.

By proposing the inter-accessible point of inference, this dissertation attempts to make the Yogācāra model of meaning more dependently arisen, distancing Yogācāra from this grammarian.

2.7.9 Arguing against Madhyamaka

Yogācāra confronted the Madhyamaka’s radical conventionalism, which argued that phenomena are merely nominal. Sthiramati’s primary concern was not the Madhyamaka’s alleged “ontological nihilism *per se*”, but the threat posed by this stance to the meaningfulness of salvific discourse (Tzohar 2018, 156-157). He saw the Madhyamaka’s view as potentially leading to the collapse of philosophical discourse. Madhyamaka’s view implied that language is self-referential, serving merely to manifest its own demise.

Sthiramati argued that the Madhyamaka’s idea of “convention without a basis (*upādāna*) does not make sense” (Tzohar 2018, 173). He contended that conventionalism without an underlying extra-nominal reality would be incoherent, leading to the nonexistence of phenomena even conventionally (Tzohar 2018). For Sthiramati, consciousness, being dependently originated, “exists as a substrate (*dravyataḥ*)” (Tzohar 2018, 173). He elaborated that “the transformation of consciousness” (*vijñāna-pariṇāma*) serves not only as an

ontological causal foundation for phenomena but also as the “referential pole” or “locus of reference” for all language, including metaphors (Tzohar 2018, 175).

Yogācāra’s theory allows for “different modes of language use, layered in accordance with their respective standing vis-à-vis knowledge of causality” (Tzohar 2018, 188). This layered understanding allows the Yogācāra to “escape the problem of self-undermining” (Tzohar 2018, 176). It also enables the school to address the “problem of incommensurability” (Tzohar 2018, 176), that is, how enlightened beings and ordinary individuals can converse meaningfully despite vast epistemic differences, by appealing to an underlying causal reality, which is partially refuted by this dissertation through taking different underlying mental causal processes as starting points for inference.

2.7.10 Reification

As mentioned by Tzohar (2018), Yogācāra thinkers, particularly Asaṅga and Sthiramati, extensively critique the notion that phenomena possess an inherent essential nature (*svabhāvatā*) that can be apprehended or revealed through language. They argue that mistaking a designatum for its essence amounts to reification.

Yogācāra philosophy, originating from Tuṣita Heaven, is a top-down framework for our understanding of the metaphor on the conceptual level within its system of reasoning. With the basic Yogācāra rules in place, it can be deduced that the primary referent of a word is ontologically nonexistent, thereby rendering Tzohar (2018) completely redundant.

On the other hand, the Buddha’s approach is broadly empirical. In a largely bottom-up manner, he inferred dependent origination, while reluctant to make explicit metaphysical claims.

Then, can we approach Yogācāra’s understanding of metaphor empirically?

After an extensive period of contemplation, I have come up with an idea to identify empirically linguistic patterns that may indicate the tendency towards reification, employing corpus linguistic methodology.

Regardless of how subtle the evidence may appear, I shall proceed. It should be noted that the following analysis is not intended to advocate Yogācāra philosophy from the perspective of

a new generation of Yogācāra Buddhists, but rather to provide an alternative way of understanding Yogācāra’s pan-metaphorism of language as reconstructed by Tzohar (2018).

Let’s depart from this *nirmita-nagara* and embark on a new journey.

3 Methodology

This chapter introduces the research methodology used in this thesis, with a focus on the corpus-assisted approach. The text under study is the English version of the Lotus Sūtra (the White Lotus of the Good Dharma), translated by 84000. This chapter explains the reasons for choosing the Lotus Sūtra as the corpus to be studied and provides an initial quantitative description of the text using the corpus linguistic tool AntConc:

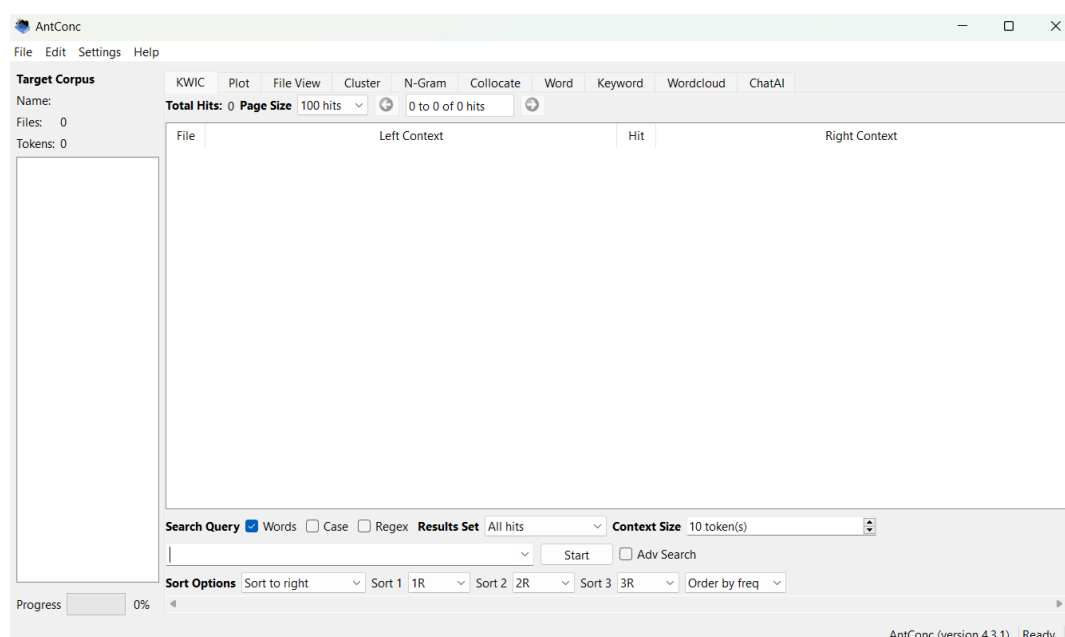


Figure 2 – Interface of AntConc.

3.1 Concerning Lotus Sūtra

The Lotus Sūtra, also known as “The White Lotus of the Good Dharma”, is one of the most popular and influential Buddhist classics, particularly in East Asia. Its significance stems from its profound teachings, its unique literary qualities, and its widespread historical and cultural impact (Tamura 2014).

The most pivotal teaching of the Lotus Sūtra is its doctrine that there is only one path, or “vehicle”, to Buddhahood (Lopez 2016). It asserts that the earlier paths of the *śrāvaka* and *pratyekabuddha* are not ultimate ends but rather provisional teachings. This concept integrates all diverse Buddhist thoughts into a single, comprehensive truth (Teiser 2009).

The sutra is considered a work of high literary quality, employing abundant metaphors, vivid parables and dramatic narratives to convey its teachings (Teiser 2009). Notable parables include the burning house, the rich man and his poor son, the magic city, and the physician and his children (Lopez 2016).

The reason why I have chosen this sutra is due to its extensive use of metaphors and parables, as well as the availability of the text in Sanskrit, Chinese, and Classical Tibetan. Although this dissertation studies the English version, the methods employed can be applied to future interlingual and cross-textual studies.

It should be noted that metaphors and parables in the text will not be examined from a traditional rhetorical perspective. The dissertation will not explore topics such as why “the burning house” is so compelling within the sutra’s narrative that it brings the reader directly into liberation. As is known, “the burning house” represents the world of suffering and ignorance in which sentient beings are trapped. The dissertation discusses why even such a phrase as “the world of suffering and ignorance” is metaphorical on the conceptual level within the framework of Yogācāra’s metaphor theory, a task not undertaken by Tzohar (2018).

3.2 Botanical, Brahmanical, or Buddhist?

An expedition team composed of a botanist, a Brahmin, and a Buddhist arrives at a scripture repository. The attention of the three is caught by a scripture shining white beams. It’s the Lotus Sūtra. The three begin to argue, each maintaining that the sutra belongs to their own school.

Let the corpus tool AntConc be the judge.

3.2.1 Target corpus building

The very beginning of a corpus linguistic study is to build a corpus. First, let's download the English translation of the Lotus Sūtra from the link: <https://84000.co/translation/toh113>. All the words and sentences to be analysed later in this dissertation are cited from 84000 (2025).

There are 27 chapters in his English translation, each saved as a separate text file. These files are then loaded into AntConc to build a corpus of the Lotus Sūtra as our target corpus, the corpus to be investigated:

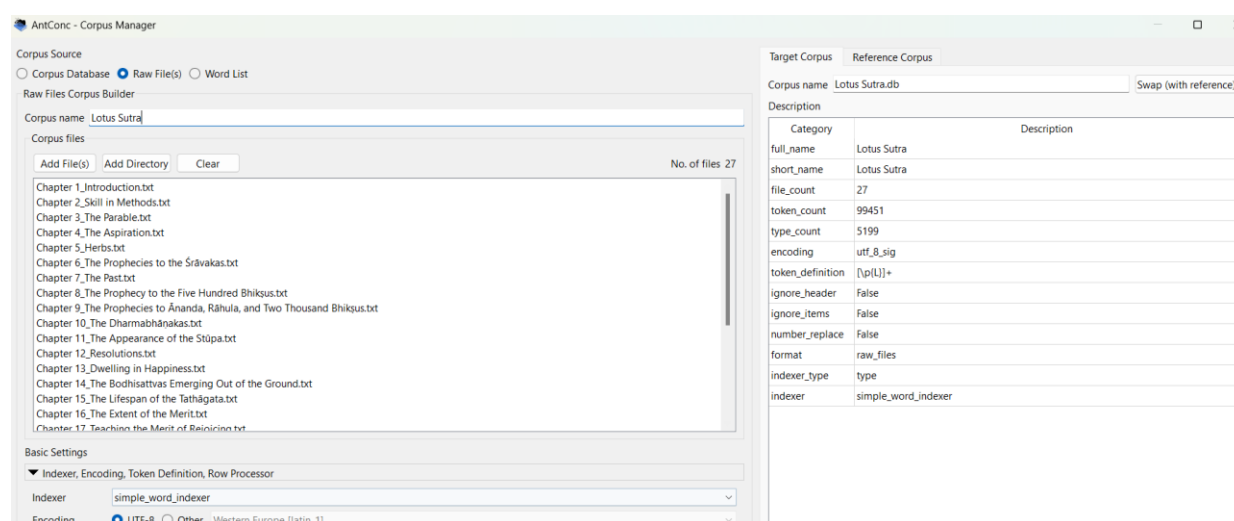


Figure 3 – Building target corpus of Lotus Sūtra.

3.2.2 Reference corpus building

What is a reference corpus? How is it understood in relation to a target corpus?

A target corpus is the specific collection of texts or data under study, like the corpus of the Lotus Sūtra that has been built, usually narrower in scope or focused on a particular genre. In contrast, a reference corpus is a large collection of texts that aims to include a wide variety of genres, making it balanced in topics and representative of the language as a whole. Such a corpus can serve as a baseline for linguistic analysis. The British National Corpus is used as the reference corpus for this dissertation:

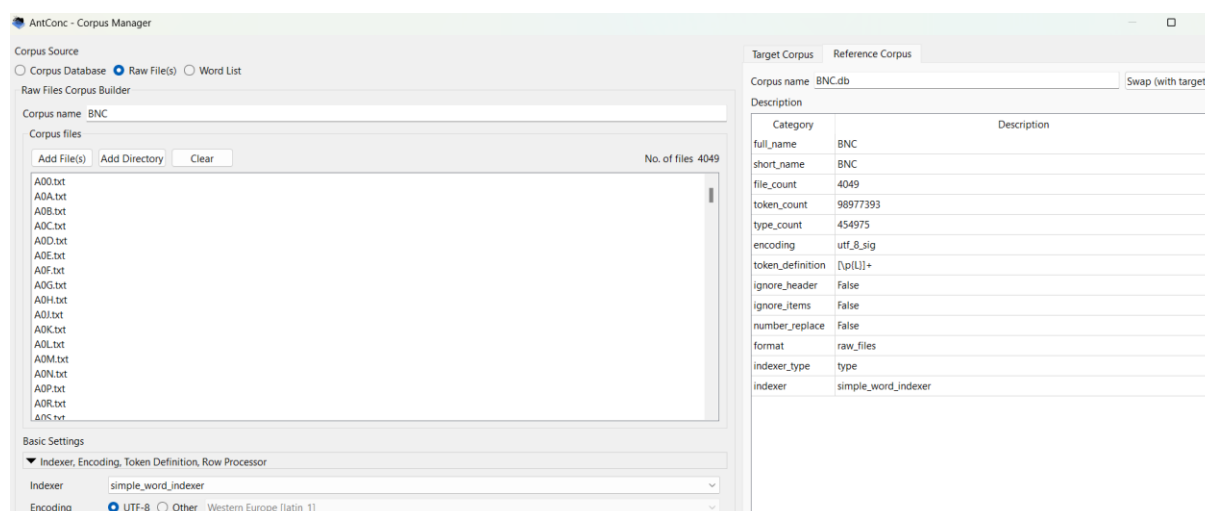


Figure 4 – Building reference corpus of BNC.

The reference corpus is not built simply for fun.

3.2.3 Keywords

This pair of corpora is built for calculating keywords.

Keywords in corpus linguistics are words that appear significantly more frequently in a target corpus compared to a reference corpus.

Suppose we have two corpora. One is a target corpus with a collection of medical research articles. The other is a reference corpus that is a large, general English language corpus, containing everyday texts from newspapers, novels, and conversations covering a full range of topics.

Based on our common sense, the word “diagnosis” is expected to occur more frequently in the medical texts than in general language. A corpus linguistic tool can also identify it as one of the keywords in the target corpus by comparing two corpora.

Now, let’s compare the two corpora that have been built in the previous section:

Table 1 – Keywords of Lotus Sūtra

Type	Rank	Freq_Tar	Freq_Ref	Keyness (Likelihood)	Keyness (Effect)
dharma	1	987	25	13403.92	0.02
bhagavān	2	839	0	11591.98	0.017
tathāgata	3	570	0	7873.814	0.011
bodhisattva	4	455	4	6238.811	0.009
beings	5	565	1743	5239.16	0.011
buddha	6	411	180	4950.577	0.008
bhikṣus	7	253	0	3494.06	0.005
nirvāṇa	8	248	0	3424.995	0.005
bodhisattvas	9	238	1	3273.92	0.005
arhat	10	224	0	3093.49	0.004
buddhas	11	229	9	3085.965	0.005
mahāsattva	12	221	0	3052.053	0.004
enlightenment	13	285	512	2897.795	0.006
enlightened	14	284	517	2881.655	0.006
tathāgatas	15	205	0	2831.057	0.004

In this table, “type” can be regarded as “word”. “Freq_Tar” and “Freq_Ref” represent the frequencies of word occurrences in the target and reference corpora, respectively. The other statistics can be ignored for now.

If the reader has not developed a “metaphomania” from so much discussion about metaphors, they would not interpret the “Buddha” as a metaphor for “Shiva”, or understand “*nirvāṇa*” as the metaphor for “withering of a lotus as a plant”.

Apologies, my dear botanist and Brahmin! Quantitative analysis confirms that the Lotus Sūtra is undeniably Buddhist.

3.3 Looking for “lotusness”

“Why is the Lotus Sūtra named as such? What is the rationale behind naming a Buddhist scripture after a plant?” The botanist raises a pointed question, evidently expressing his skepticism.

Let’s turn to AntConc again to look for “lotusness” in the corpus.

3.3.1 Occurrences of “lotus” and “lotuses”

We can search for “lotus” and “lotuses” in the corpus:

Table 2 – Frequencies of “lotus” and “lotuses”

Type	Rank	Freq	Range	NormFreq	NormRange
lotus	1	128	27	1287.066	1
lotuses	2	19	10	191.049	0.37

As shown in the table, the lexical item “lotus” occurs 128 times across 27 chapters, while “lotuses” appears 19 times in 10 chapters.

3.3.2 Distribution of “lotus” and “lotuses”

Considering “lotus” and “lotuses” collectively, we can further investigate their distribution throughout the corpus:

Table 3 – Distribution of “lotus” and “lotuses”

Row	FilePath	FileTokens	Freq	NormFreq
1	Chapter 23	3079	19	6170.835
2	Chapter 25	2800	7	2500
3	Chapter 22	3872	23	5940.083
4	Chapter 11	6624	27	4076.087
5	Chapter 26	2292	18	7853.403
6	Chapter 19	1995	4	2005.013
7	Chapter 1	5777	5	865.501
8	Chapter 20	1711	4	2337.814
9	Chapter 21	1278	4	3129.89
10	Chapter 3	8615	3	348.23
11	Chapter 7	8868	6	676.59
12	Chapter 17	2009	3	1493.28
13	Chapter 18	4382	5	1141.031
14	Chapter 2	7019	1	142.47
15	Chapter 4	4459	1	224.266
16	Chapter 5	5006	1	199.76
17	Chapter 6	2323	1	430.478
18	Chapter 8	3165	1	315.956
19	Chapter 9	1748	1	572.082
20	Chapter 10	2871	1	348.311
21	Chapter 12	1487	1	672.495
22	Chapter 13	4357	1	229.516
23	Chapter 14	3992	2	501.002
24	Chapter 15	2762	1	362.056
25	Chapter 16	3490	2	573.066

26	Chapter 24	2706	3	1108.647
27	Chapter 27	764	2	2617.801

In this table, “FilePath” denotes the subcorpus, which is each chapter of the sutra. “FileTokens” refers roughly to the word count of each subcorpus. “Freq” is Frequencies, meaning the occurrences of “lotus” and “lotuses” that are being examined. “NormFreq” stands for “Normalized Frequency”, a measure used in corpus linguistics tools to represent the frequency of a lexical item relative to the size of the corpus or subcorpus being analysed.

It can be interpreted from the result that “lotus” and “lotuses” occur most frequently on average in Chapter 23 Gadgadasvara, where Gadgadasvara and the bodhisattvas accompanying him attain the *samādhī* called “manifestation of all forms,” symbolising their profound ability to teach and guide all beings in suitable ways. The profusion of lotuses can be considered to signify the innumerable merits and virtues of Gadgadasvara and his retinue, highlighting their transcendental qualities and their dedication to teaching the Dharma to all beings.

3.3.3 Company of “lotus” and “lotuses”

A well-known aphorism by the linguist J.R. Firth states, “You shall know a word by the company it keeps” (Firth, 1957):

Table 4 – Company of “lotus” and “lotuses”

Collocate	Rank	FreqL	FreqR	Range	Likelihood
dharma	1	107	106	27	797.308
white	2	120	2	27	792.381
good	3	0	106	18	587.362
teaching	4	107	0	27	406.318
of	5	114	107	27	265.507
the	6	138	125	27	156.65
blue	7	9	0	6	64.636
lotuses	8	5	5	1	53.468
petals	9	2	3	3	26.205

In this table, “FreqL” and “FreqR” describe the frequency of co-occurrence of words in the left or right contexts of a target word, while “Likelihood” measures the strength of these collocates. The data suggest that “lotus” and “lotuses” are meaningfully associated with such terms as “dharma”, “white (purity)”, and “teaching”.

3.4 Summary

This chapter aims to demonstrate the statistical acumen of the corpus linguistics tool AntConc.

During the course of writing this dissertation, the platform Dharmamitra has been launched. Its strengths include translation between Buddhist languages, grammatical analysis and interlingual parallel search. However, it has not been equipped with the functionalities unique to corpus software as displayed previously in this dissertation. Additionally, it is impossible for Dharmamitra to carry out inter-sectarian investigations of non-Buddhist and Buddhist texts as Tzohar (2018) does, since it is designed specifically for Buddhist studies.

On the other hand, when it comes to corpus linguistics, there is currently no tool specialised for Buddhist languages, making it challenging to process these languages effectively. It is possible for these tools to conduct inter-sectarian studies of non-Buddhist and Buddhist texts in Sanskrit, yet a considerable amount of work is required.

Technological gaps remain to be addressed.

4 Analysis of Lotus Sūtra: traces of reification

Although the Lotus Sūtra is abundant with metaphors and parables, these belong to the domain of traditional rhetorical studies and are not the focus of this chapter. It has to be reiterated that Yogācāra's theory of metaphor operates on the conceptual level rather than from a rhetorical perspective and Tzohar (2018) falls short of demonstrating why such terms as “the other-dependent pattern”, which is the tenor for a series of vehicles of “a magic trick, a mirage, a dream trace, a shadow, a reflection, a valley echo, the moon in water”, is metaphorical on the conceptual level within the framework of Yogācāra's pan-metaphorism, although Yogācāra philosophy has already entailed the absence of the primary referent in a top-down manner.

This chapter attempts to approach in a bottom-up manner Yogācāra's pan-metaphorism from the perspective of traces of reification that can be observed in linguistic data. Reification is discussed in §§ 2.7.10.

4.1 Observation of metaphor (rhetorical) within parables

The parable of the burning house depicts a burning house representing the world of suffering. A father uses the promise of various carts as rewards to entice his children to escape the danger. This skillful means symbolises the Buddha’s compassionate expedients to liberate sentient beings. In this parable, “a burning house” stands for the world of *saṃsāra* full of suffering.

The parable of the medicinal herbs recounts that beings receive the Dharma according to their capacities, as different herbs respond to the same rain according to their nature. In this parable, “rain” stands for the Dharma.

4.2 Reification and superimposition of qualities

The following analysis aims to demonstrate that terms such as *saṃsāra*, suffering, *dharma* are already metaphorical on the conceptual level within Yogācāra’s framework of pan-metaphorism. The reason why they can be regarded as metaphorical on the conceptual level is that linguistic evidence indicates to some extent that they undergo a process of reification, acquiring superimposed qualities apparently not belonging to them. Consequently, they are not essentially different from rhetorical metaphors such as “the burning house” and “rain”.

4.3 Suffering

From all the concordance lines containing the term “suffering”, I select the following as a subset:

Table 5 – Suffering¹⁵

I have saved you from the	suffering	Of being burned for many millions of eons
You are freed from the	suffering	of saṃsāra, But you have still not attained nirvāṇa.
Free beings from	suffering!	The Lamp of the World is difficult to find,
and frees them from all	suffering.	It is like a pond for those who are
The White Lotus of the Good Dharma frees from all	suffering.	It ends all illness. It frees from all the
Devas ³³⁸ and humans will be in	suffering.	There will then be, in succession, A full five
run out And stand in the open air, freed from	suffering.	When the man sees his children have come out
I will teach extensively The Dharma that liberates from	suffering.”	At that time Śāriputra said to the daughter of
I shall save the children from immense	suffering.’	Because of that approach, the man would not be
And immersed in a continuum of	suffering.	Bound to craving, the fools are like yaks; ¹⁵⁵ They

¹⁵ The original sentences are cited from 84000 (2025).

From expressions such as “saved from”, “free/frees/freed from”, “in”, “liberate from” and “immersed in”, it can be inferred that “suffering”, a mental causal process (following Tzohar’s terminology), is superimposed with the quality of physical confinement, reifying it as an external entity. In §§ 2.6.2.1, I claim that all metaphors can be traced to the root metaphor (√ metaphor) with the interplay between the non-existent self (*ātman*) and phenomena (*dharma*) as its soil. Therefore, the schema for *suffering* as metaphor is “the self contained in a phenomenon”.

4.4 Saṃsāra

In the same vein, similar patterns can be observed with the term “*saṃsāra*”:

Table 6 – *Saṃsāra*¹⁶

The Tathāgata has compassion for the beings in	saṃsāra,	and although he has transcended the three realms he
great ²⁷¹ ignorance Like the born-blind man, and continue in	saṃsāra.	Because they do not know the cycle of dependent
taught you nirvāṇa. You are freed from the suffering of	saṃsāra,	But you have still not attained nirvāṇa. You need
They are sunk in	saṃsāra,	enveloped in misery, And immersed in a continuum of
the blind man represents the beings who dwell in the	saṃsāra	of the five kinds of existences. Those who do
cycle of saṃsāra and do not know how to leave	saṃsāra.	Seeing them he knows, ‘These beings, because of their
Within	saṃsāra,	we have had an inferior aspiration.

From the expressions such as “in”, “freed from”, “sunk in”, “dwell in”, “leave” and “within”, it can be inferred that “*saṃsāra*”, a mental causal process, is also superimposed with the quality of physical confinement, reifying it as an external entity.

Therefore, the schema for *saṃsāra* as metaphor is also “the self contained in a phenomenon”.

4.5 Nirvāṇa

The same applies to “*nirvāṇa*”:

¹⁶ The original sentences are cited from 84000 (2025).

Table 7 – *Nirvāṇa*¹⁷

where the Tathāgata has passed into	nirvāṇa	, and in the buddha realms where the Bhagavān
May I enter	nirvāṇa	, peace , on this very day. ’
When the Protector of Humans is in	nirvāṇa	. { 37 } 16.63 “ Through that they

From the expressions such as “passed”, “enter” and “in”, it can be inferred that “*nirvāṇa*”, a mental causal process, is superimposed with the quality of a physical spatial area, reifying it as an external entity.

Therefore, the schema for *nirvāṇa* as metaphor is “the self towards a phenomenon”.

4.6 Dharma

This section investigates the adjectives that modify the term “*dharma*”:

Table 8 – *Dharma*

Type	Rank	Freq	Range	NormFreq	NormRange
great dharma	1	11	1	88.512	0.037
supreme dharma	1	11	5	88.512	0.185
highest dharma	3	9	7	72.419	0.259
good dharma	4	7	5	56.326	0.185
many dharmas	5	5	5	40.233	0.185
entire dharma	6	4	2	32.186	0.074
many dharma	6	4	2	32.186	0.074
profound dharma	6	4	2	32.186	0.074
pure dharma	6	4	3	32.186	0.111
profound dharmas	11	2	2	16.093	0.074
stainless dharma	11	2	2	16.093	0.074
vast dharma	11	2	2	16.093	0.074
amazing dharma	15	1	1	8.047	0.037
beautiful dharma	15	1	1	8.047	0.037
clean dharma	15	1	1	8.047	0.037
excellent dharma	15	1	1	8.047	0.037
final dharma	15	1	1	8.047	0.037
first dharma	15	1	1	8.047	0.037
glorious dharma	15	1	1	8.047	0.037
marvelous dharma	15	1	1	8.047	0.037
much dharma	15	1	1	8.047	0.037
perfect dharma	15	1	1	8.047	0.037
secret dharma	15	1	1	8.047	0.037

¹⁷ The original sentences are cited from 84000 (2025)

subtle dharma	15	1	1	8.047	0.037
superior dharma	15	1	1	8.047	0.037
supreme dharmas	15	1	1	8.047	0.037
true dharma	15	1	1	8.047	0.037
wonderful dharma	15	1	1	8.047	0.037
wonderful dharmas	15	1	1	8.047	0.037

As manifested by the table, the term “*dharma*” denotes something measured, graded, and numbered. However, *dharma* should be immeasurable, ungradable and innumerable. It can be inferred that “*dharma*”, a mental causal process, is superimposed with the quality of something under evaluation, reifying it as an external entity.

Therefore, the schema for *dharma* as metaphor is “the self evaluates a phenomenon”.

As we can see, suffering, *saṃsāra*, *nirvāṇa* and *dharma* are as metaphorical as “the burning house” and “the rain”, superimposed with imagined qualities.

5 Conclusion

Due to the ticking clock driven by the fleeting time, I have to bring my writing to a close.

Based on my summary and critical review of Tzohar (2018), this dissertation examines Sthiramati’s pan-metaphorism of language as reconstructed in this book. Tzohar (2018) investigates the inter-sectarian debates on the notion of *upacāra* between non-Buddhist schools of Indian philosophy and Buddhist traditions. Moreover, it presents a formula central to *upacāra*, namely, that the primary referent is absent from its locus of reference, and details how this formula is variably interpreted within different schools of thought.

The dissertation has pointed out the necessity to distinguish the metaphor on the conceptual level within Yogācāra’s framework of reasoning from the traditional one from a rhetorical perspective. Tzohar (2018) somehow blurs the boundary. To offer an alternative to Tzohar’s (2018) proposal of the underlying mental causal process as the common ground for the communication between a simpleton and a bodhisattva, the dissertation puts forward the concept of “the inter-accessible point of inference”.

In the meanwhile, Tzohar (2018) falls short of demonstrating why such terms as “the other-dependent pattern”, which is the tenor for a series of vehicles of “a magic trick, a mirage, a dream trace, a shadow, a reflection, a valley echo, the moon in water”, is metaphorical on the conceptual level within the framework of Yogācāra’s pan-metaphorism, although Yogācāra philosophy has already entailed the absence of the primary referent in a top-down manner. To address this issue, the dissertation attempts a corpus-assisted study to approach in a bottom-up manner Yogācāra’s pan-metaphorism from the perspective of traces of reification as an indication for metaphor on the conceptual level. Based on the assumption of “root metaphor ($\sqrt{\text{metaphor}}$)” proposed in §§ 2.6.2.1, the dissertation has found three schemata for the metaphors of suffering, *saṃsāra*, *nirvāṇa* and *dharma* in terms of the non-existent “self” and “phenomena”, i.e., “the self contained in a phenomenon”, “the self towards a phenomenon”, and “the self evaluates a phenomenon”.

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